

and promote self-care without compromising on safety, set up a committee last year to formulate a fresh OTC drug policy for India.

The Indian OTC drugs market is projected to grow from approximately ₹55,600 crore in 2024 to ₹72,800 crore by 2029, at a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of 5.39%, according to Mordor Intelligence, a market research and advisory firm.

“While self-medication is often seen as convenient and cost-effective, it carries serious risks, such as adverse reactions, dangerous drug interactions, and the worsening of undiagnosed conditions,” Dr Ajay Agarwal, Senior Director of Internal Medicine, Fortis Hospital, Noida, tells *Business Today*.

Rising OTC drug sales have raised concerns over anti-microbial resistance of medicines. Medicines, including antibiotics, are available easily without prescriptions. “Antibiotics are among the most misused drugs... The misuse of antibiotics contributes to antimicrobial resistance, a global health crisis,” Agarwal says.

Despite health concerns, the increasing popularity of OTC drugs has led to pharma majors seizing the chance to diversify their revenue streams.

WHAT THE LEADERS ARE DOING

LupinLife, consumer healthcare division of pharma giant Lupin, is refining its portfolio and market strategy to meet the changing needs of health-conscious consumers. “Our focus has been on key OTC categories such as gastrointestinal health, vitamins and supplements, with a strong emphasis on women’s and children’s health,” says Anil V. Kaushal, Head of LupinLife Consumer Healthcare. “Staying attuned

to the voice of the consumer and leveraging Lupin’s legacy in health-care, we aim to build enduring trust in the consumer health market,” Kaushal says.

Building on Lupin’s legacy in prescription drugs, the division is aiming to leverage its established trust in the consumer health market. Recent product launches like Softovac Liqui-Fibre, an ayurvedic bowel regulator, is a new take on the liquid laxative category.

Another long-established player in the prescription drug market, Glenmark Pharmaceuticals, is also expanding its portfolio of wellness products, like Acnil and Kare Aloe Vera Gel. It aims to capture a significant share of the wellness market. “We are improving access to our established OTC brands such as Candid, La Shield (a sunscreen range), and Scalpe,” Alok Malik, President and Business Head-India

Formulations at Glenmark Pharmaceuticals Ltd, says.

The German pharmaceutical major, Bayer, is also expanding its consumer health and OTC portfolios. “Over recent years, Bayer has expanded its consumer health and OTC portfolio to meet the evolving needs of the market,” Sandeep Verma, Country Head for India, Bangladesh, and Sri Lanka at Bayer’s Consumer Health Division, says. He says that the company is capitalising on the increasing consumer preference for self-care products.

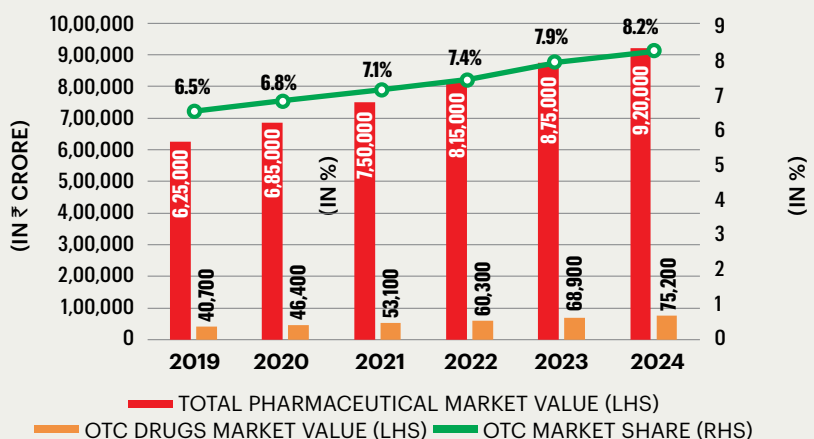
PERSONAL HEALTH, NEW KID ON THE BLOCK

The popularity of social media platforms like Instagram and the boom in the digital marketing ecosystem have increased access to information. The rising popularity of skincare and personal health has

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GROWTH TRAJECTORY

• India’s pharma market grew from ₹7 lakh crore in 2019 to ₹8 lakh crore in 2024. In the same period, the OTC drugs market share increased from just over 6.5% to 8%



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